

ON TECHNIQUE

Transcendentalism

Liszt's operatic paraphrases took themes from operas past and present (Mozart's *Don Giovanni*, among others) and reworked them for the piano, often in blatantly barnstorming style. In the 12 *Études d'exécution transcendante* (Studies in Transcendental Execution), the emphasis is different: extreme technical difficulty is an aspect of the music to be absorbed and then left behind, so that the pianist's imagination is free to roam on a higher plane of artistry. With their soaring Romantic inspiration and inventive range, the *Études* can perhaps be regarded as Liszt's greatest single achievement.

Abbé Liszt and the last years

In 1860, intending that she and Liszt should at last marry, Carolyné traveled to Rome to try to secure a papal annulment of her Catholic marriage to her aristocratic husband. Local intrigue had undermined Liszt's position in Weimar, and he resigned his post to join her in Rome. Then came a sequence of disasters. When Carolyné's annulment was repeatedly blocked, she suffered a breakdown, and lapsed into eccentricity, seldom leaving her apartment, where she spent the rest of her life writing a 24-volume religious tract. Liszt's son, Daniel, had died of tuberculosis in 1859; now his daughter Blandine died, too, of post-natal complications. His surviving daughter, Cosima, although already married, began a relationship with Wagner; despite a longstanding friendship with his fellow composer, Liszt at first deeply disapproved, until he realized that her divorce and second marriage were inevitable. For several years he lived in a cell in a local